SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #21 · WORK AND IDENTITY

“I am what I do for a living.”

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Where it often comes from

“What do you do?” is often the first question we are asked, and the answer can quietly become who we are. A family that prized a certain career, a profession with long training, or a parent whose identity was their job can teach us to merge the two. This works while the job is going well. When the role changes, ends, or disappoints, the person underneath can feel lost.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture honors work. God worked in creation, and Paul tells us to work with our whole being, as for the Lord. But Scripture places identity before work. We are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, and the works come from who we are, not the other way around. We are made in God’s image and called by Him. A job is one place where we serve, but it is not the name God calls us by.

> *“For we are God’s workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life”* (Ephesians 2:10).

Also see

> “So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them” (Genesis 1:27).

> “Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men” (Colossians 3:23).

> “But you are a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for God’s own possession, to proclaim the virtues of Him who called you out of darkness into His marvelous light” (1 Peter 2:9).

> “‘Before I formed you in the womb I knew you, and before you were born I set you apart and appointed you as a prophet to the nations.’” (Jeremiah 1:5).

Common self-statements

- If I am not my job, I do not know who I am.
- My title is my identity.
- When people ask what I do, that is who I am.
- If my work is ordinary, so am I.
- Without my role, I disappear.
- I only matter when I am working.

Common logical errors

- Labeling: Reducing myself to a title.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that my identity is either my job or nothing.
- Mental filter: Seeing only the work part of who I am.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling empty when work changes and concluding that I am empty.

Challenging questions

- If someone asked who I am without using my job, what would I say?

- What roles, relationships, and values make up my identity besides work?
- What does God call me, and when did He call me that?
- How did my family treat work and identity?
- What do I lose if I let work define me?
- What qualities would remain if my job changed tomorrow?

Truth summary

> My work is a good thing I do, not the whole of who I am. I was made in God's image and made His workmanship in Christ before I did any job. I can do my work well and hold my title loosely.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Occupation/Job/Work
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Worldly
- Humility
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Unemployment

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

In Christ Alone — Keith and Kristyn Getty with Alison Krauss
Security and salvation rest in Christ's life, death, and resurrection.

How Great Thou Art — Jordan Smith
This classic hymn connects God's greatness, Christ's sacrifice, and future hope.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I am what I do for a living"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I am what I do for a living." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who am I without my job?
- ☐ What do others value in me besides my work?
- ☐ What does God call me?
- ☐ What would remain if my role changed?
- ☐ What do I enjoy that has nothing to do with work?
- ☐ How can I introduce myself differently?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am more than my job.
- ☐ I am God's workmanship.
- ☐ My work flows from who I am, not the reverse.
- ☐ I can enjoy my work without being defined by it.
- ☐ My identity cannot be fired.
- ☐ God calls me by name, not by title.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Ephesians 2:10
  "For we are God's workmanship, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared in advance as our way of life."
- ☐ Genesis 1:27
  "So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them."
- ☐ 1 Peter 2:9
  "But you are a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for God's own possession, to proclaim the virtues of Him who called you out of darkness into His marvelous light."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] More than my job: Each day, write one thing about yourself that has nothing to do with your work.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Ephesians 2:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am God's workmanship, so my identity is more than my job.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Occupation/Job/Work" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Write "I am..." sentences without work. Complete ten sentences about who you are that do not mention a job.
- [ ] Introduce yourself differently. Next time you meet someone, share something about your family, faith, or interests before your job.
- [ ] Ask someone close. Ask a friend or family member what they value about you besides your work.
- [ ] Read the verse aloud. Say Ephesians 2:10 each morning.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I am what I do for a living": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Who I am beyond work
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I am what I do for a living.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You made me and called me Yours before I did any work. Free me from being defined by my title. Help me work well and rest in who You say I am. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.